The Mihai Eminescu Trust

Newsletter 2006

WHOLE VILLAGE PROJECT

The EU has acknowledged the value of the MET's conservation work by granting financial support, through the Culture 2000 programme, to our "Whole Village Project - an Integrated Approach to Cultural Heritage Conservation in Saxon Transylvania". This enables the MET and its partners - Corona Association, Horizon Foundation and Fundatia MET Sighisoara - to expand their heritage restoration and training work.

As part of this project, in September we held our first 10-day international workshop in Malancrav and its surrounding villages, dedicated to traditional building methods and materials. The workshop combined theory with practice in brickwork, lime mortar, carpentry, historic interiors and mural paintings. Some 40 participants from Romania, Germany, the UK and Holland shared their knowledge and expertise under the supervision of conservation specialists and craftsmen including Colin Richards, conservation officer with South Shropshire Council, Anthony Goode, lime practitioner and SPAB trainer, Cecily Brunner and Mary Gatacre, decorative artists and scenic painters, and Jan Huelsemann, conservation architect.

The recently appointed British Ambassador to Romania, Robin Barnett, attended the last day of the Malancrav seminars and stayed in the MET's guesthouse with his wife and escorts.

The second workshop will take place in May 2007 in Viscri, Crit and Mesendorf.



GABRIEL LAMBESCU's sudden death in July was a sad blow. He was the greatest friend to the Mihai Eminescu Trust, to Romanian architectural heritage and to all who worked with him. We are lucky to have the architect Jan Huelsemann on secondment from Germany, funded by the Packard Humanities Institute, the Centre for International Migration Germany (CIM), and the German World Heritage Foundation. He is assisted by two excellent young architects from Cluj and Bucharest and is training them in conservation.

VISCRI AREA

36 restoration projects have been completed and another six are under way in Viscri, Cloasterf, Mesendorf, Saschiz, Bunesti and Crit.

The Bunesti church received special attention with repairs completed on the previously collapsed tower and a damaged buttress. We also enlisted the help of our architects to assess the overall situation of the church and produce a proposal for full restoration.

In the Mesendorf church, the stonework of one of the fortification towers has been repaired.

In May, Caroline Fernolend and Gabriel Lambescu held the first in a series of workshops for villagers on practical and theoretical training in conservation practice. Colleagues from Hosman, Apold, Cabor and Sighisoara attended. Gabriel also presented our traditional conservation work in Medias Town Hall, along with INTBAU architects.

HRH The Prince of Wales came on a private visit in May to see the Trust's work and walk in the hills and valleys surrounding the Saxon villages. He stayed two nights in Viscri with Caroline and Walther Fernolend acting as hosts.

In June the Viscri museum was opened officially by Bishop Klein.

LASLEA AREA

In Floresti, the exterior of the Saxon Church has been fully restored, with stonework repairs, plaster and painting, as well as a new wooden staircase leading up to the balcony. Work on the inside is continuing during the winter. The Orthodox Church exterior has also been painted. Three other houses have been repaired, including the Village Hall. There is also a new wooden bridge over the village stream, in front of the Church, built to a design of Gabriel Lambescu.

In Malancrav, aside from the Manor House (see below), the Catholic Church has been fully restored, inside and out (enabling the priest from Sighisoara to hold a special service on St. Mary's feast day) and four other houses have undergone repairs. The Town Hall donated free cobbles and we repaved part of the walkways in front of several houses.

In Laslea, we completed the major restoration project of no. 344, soon to open as an Information Centre, under the aegis of INTBAU, the international group promoting traditional building and architecture. We have also produced architectural and engineering surveys needed for the restoration of another critically endangered historic house, no. 162.

In Noul Sasesc, the area around the Greek-Catholic church has been cleared and part of the roof repaired to stop further damage over winter.

BIODIVERSITY

Without lessening our focus on saving endangered buildings, this year we have devoted almost equal attention to biodiversity conservation, conscious that the natural and built heritages complement each other and should be seen as a whole.



Breite Oak Reserve

Appointed joint managers of Breite Ancient Oak Tree Reserve in March, the MET and Sighisoara Local Council have hired permanent guards, put up information boards, organised a public information campaign and held a debate about the management of the reserve. We have also funded a historical study of Breite and launched the website www.breite.ro. The management plan is nearly completed.

Natura 2000

The MET has provided a significant part of the funding for biodiversity research for proposed Natura 2000 sites in Transylvania, enabling our biologists to undertake extensive field research in ornithology, herpetology and botany, in order to fill in the standard data forms for the 'Sighisoara – Tarnava Mare' special area of conservation and for the 'Breite – Bradeni' special protection area under the Birds Directive. Together with EPA Mures, we published and distributed copies of an information brochure entitled 'What is Natura 2000?'

Ecological education

Under the supervision of Tibor Hartel, professor of biology, educational links have been established with schools in Sighisoara and Tirgu Mures. Pupils were involved in a variety of wildlife projects, including special studies of pond wildlife on Breite, measuring oak trees, learning how to use a GPS and identifying species of flora and fauna.

Studies and publications

The MET sponsored the 2nd edition of *Scripta Ornitologica Romaniae* magazine, edited by the Faculty of Biology and Geology of the Babes-Bolyai University and the Cluj branch of the Romanian Academy.

We also supported field research and mapping for a special bird protection area around the Bradeni Lake, south of Sighisoara. The proposal was approved by the Romanian Academy.

We helped finance part of the research for two studies published in international magazines: *"Habitat Use of Amphibian Communities in the Tarnava Mare Valley, Romania"*, by Tibor Hartel, Laszlo Demeter and Dan Cogalniceanu (with Declining Amphibian Populations Task Force), and *"The situation of Crex crex populations in the Medias Plateau, Romania"*, by Cosmin Ioan Moga (with the British Ornithological Union).

Tibi Hartel accompanied groups of visitors from the UK and Germany on walking tours around the Saxon villages and on Breite, providing in-depth information about the biodiversity and landscape of the area. His most prominent visitor was HRH Prince of Wales, together with Patrick Holden, head of the Soil Association.

BRICK AND TILE KILN

Colin Richards, South Shropshire District Council's conservation officer, has overseen the building of a kiln in Viscri, which will produce 12,000 handmade roof tiles and 4,000 bricks in one firing. The kiln will be run by a local family, reviving a craft that had nearly disappeared and providing much needed traditional building materials for Transylvanian architects and restorers. The first firing in October was highly successful. We are deeply indebted to Colin for his generous hard work, his five visits and the gift of his time to the Trust, as well as to his son, Joe, and three of his colleagues - Paul Russell, Ludlow Town Clerk, Robert Demaus and Noel Knight.

MALANCRAV MANOR

Furnishings for the interior of the house are being made in the village. Fittings such as hinges, bolts, locks, handles and curtain rods have been handmade following historic patterns. It is a big challenge for all, the architect as well as the craftsmen in Sighisoara, Sibiu, Viscri, Gura Raului, Nades, and Rupea, to design and make all these items. In this way, we are not just restoring an important physical monument, but also keeping old skills alive, reviving them where they are lost, and moreover contributing to the survival of small-scale enterprises.

The exterior is finished except for some small sections of plasterwork in the porch and above the main door. The steps on the north and south side were quarried and dressed by a Hungarian firm, Bartalis Bela, owned and managed by stonemasons from father to son since the reign of Maria Theresa. On site, work was partly executed by Tom Waugh and Payson Muller, with bursaries from the Prince's Foundation - under the supervision of master stonemason Henry Rumbold. The iron railings are being wrought in the workshop of blacksmith Ioan Jinariu near Sibiu.

MALANCRAV MANOR GARDEN

During the autumn, site preparation of the garden continued and resulted in the exciting archaeological discovery of the original central pond and the steps leading up to the *Tanzplatz*. The garden is now ready for planting in the spring.



ARCHITECTS FOR AID

We have forged a partnership with Architects for Aid, a British charity providing architects to work with charities on endangered buildings, post conflict reconstruction and development projects. A4A is assembling a delegation of experienced and trainee architects, who will visit Transylvania in February 2007 to record and catalogue ancient Saxon village buildings and subsequently work on their restoration.

AGRICULTURE AND RURAL DEVELOPMENT

The MET, Sighisoara Town Hall and Geomed Impex 2002 started the process of establishing a Local Action Group to access EU funds through the Leader Plus programme. Three public meetings took place in Sighisoara and more than 40 signatures have been gathered.

Our organic apple juice is reaching wider markets in Sibiu, Targu Mures, Brasov, Sighisoara and Bucharest. 20,000 litres were produced this autumn. We are also working with Biocoop, the association of organic food producers, to open a shop in Sighisoara.

VILLAGES

In Axente Sever we donated 3300 Euro towards the restoration of the church fortification wall. The project is coordinated by OVR Netherlands and led by architect Hermann Fabini.

In Apold, our grant has enabled the Corona team to plaster and lime wash the Gate House.

We have given Agnita Town Hall a grant to restore the front of the village Museum.

In Hosman, with our help, the old maize mill has been restarted and work has continued on rehabilitation of the building itself, the establishment of the bakery and the restoration of the facade. Another house is being repaired with our support.

In Prejmer, a World Heritage site near Brasov, the MET has been approached by a local NGO to initiate a Whole Village Project. Local councillors and builders took part in our seminar in Malancrav. We are providing funding for the restoration of the facade of the oldest house in Prejmer, dating from 1777.

THE TOWER HOUSE

Restoration of this charming building on the edge of the ramparts of Sighisoara citadel is almost complete. We hope to move our office here in the spring – to be able to spread out and give more comprehensive details of the Trust's work to a wider audience.

MUSIC AND THE MET

The spirit of the simple but beautiful Samuel Maetz clavichord, restored for the Trust and Sighisoara museum by Edmund Handy, lives on. So inspired was Handy while working on the instrument that he has made a copy, exhibited at the Greenwich Festival of Early Music in November. Handy has started work on a second copy, which he will exhibit at the Festival Musica Antiqua Bruges in Belgium in summer 2007.

Anda Anastasescu, the celebrated Romanian pianist, saw the original Maetz instrument this summer. She has offered to give concerts on it in 2007.

The MET has secured funding to restore a carved organ angel as well as three organs in churches in Transylvania - Malancrav, Cloasterf and Archita.

SMALL GRANTS

We contributed 5,000 handmade traditional tiles to the restoration of a historic house in the Sighisoara citadel, next to the Tailors' Tower.

Ornithologist Cosmin Ioan Moga has received support to research the relationship between traditional farming and bird populations.

The results will be published in a scientific magazine and will be used in the application for funds to support in support of traditional agriculture.

We have also helped the Aurel Mosora secondary school in Sighisoara to repair the windows of a classroom where 19 twelve year-old pupils study.

Following the collapse of Sighisoara's citadel wall, we supported the Town Hall in requesting help from UNESCO, the EU and other institutions. The Romanian Ministry of Culture has taken on the repair work. Gabriel Lambescu took the opportunity to prepare an application to the EU Leonardo scheme with Paul Russell of Ludlow Council, for another damaged section of the ramparts – the Tinsmiths' Tower.

TOURISM

MET guesthouses have accommodated visitors from many walks of life this spring and summer. Rodney Slatford, a musician from Norfolk, played abandoned 18th century organs in many Saxon villages. His friend, a leading London chef, created innovative dishes from local produce and was surprised to encounter a bear one morning in Viscri.

INTBAU director Mathew Hardy led a 12-strong painting trip to Biertan, Richis, Floresti and Malancrav, staying in MET village houses.

Transylvania Uncovered and Reality and Beyond continue to offer specially crafted trips which include staying in our restored houses.

Articles in The Daily Telegraph, The Sunday Times, The Mail on Sunday, The Daily Mail, The BBC History Journal and the Guardian have reported on the Trust's work.

TRANSYLVANIA 40

Marianne Suhr, presenter of BBC2's architectural series 'Restoration', gave a series of talks on 'The Saxon Villages of Transylvania'. She has used the occasion to promote the MET's Transylvania 40 project. This aims to raise funds for saving a Saxon village house. Forty people contributing £250 each will secure the future of the building. They will be entitled to a two-week stay in the house for up to three years after restoration work has been completed.

EVENTS

Romanian director of the MET, Caroline Fernolend, attended the Ludlow Food & Drink Festival in Britain as a guest of the Mayor. She presented a range of homemade Transylvanian foods in the SLOW FOOD marquee and received the SLOW FOOD medal. She also attended a seminar with government ministers in Sinaia, Romania on saving cultural heritage and visited Belgium and France in November to attend colloquium and seminars about European Cultural Heritage and European citizenship.

At Slow Food's 2006 Biennale Festival in Turin, MET food adviser and Rachel Saunders promoted products from the Saxon villages.

At the INTBAU heritage conference in Venice in October, Jessica Douglas-Home gave a paper on the Saxon villages of Transylvania. She also gave a talk at the annual gathering of Sighisoaran Saxons at Dinkelsbühl, Germany about the work of the Trust. HRH Prince of Wales addressed the large gathering by video.

Earlier in the year the Mihai Eminescu Trust received a gold medal in the Austrian Ecological Tourism Awards.

RAILWAY

The MET and the New Europe Railway Heritage Trust arranged for railway experts from Transylvania to visit North Wales to discuss finance and maintenance for narrow gauge railways with the staff from the Ffestiniog and Welsh Highland railways. A NERHT delegation visited Transylvania and Bucharest in June to facilitate negotiations between the owners of the Sibiu – Agnita railway and the local authorities.

AKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Thanks are again due to the Packard Humanities Institute for their support, as well as to The Horizon Foundation and The Headley Trust. They are the backbone of all our achievements. This year we must also thank the Culture 2000 programme of the European Union for their grant in support of our Whole Village Project.

We are grateful to the Viscountess Boyd Foundation, the Rothschild Foundation, the Prodan Foundation, Sir John Smith and the owners of Holkham Hall, Sudeley Castle and Chilham Castle for generously opening their doors to host our Transylvania 40 talks.

We are also very grateful for the continuing help of David Mlinaric in planning the interior, as well as the colours, materials, furniture and countless other details of the Manor House.

We would like to thank Anthony Goode for generously sharing his knowledge on conservation practice and Patrick James of The Landscape Agency for the loan of his specialists Catherine Fitzgerald and Kirsty Stevens to help us with Malancrav Manor garden.

We would like to thank H.R. Patapievici, president of the Romanian Cultural Institute, for generously donating copies of the cultural magazine PLURAL.

We thank Rodney Leach, Monmouth Humanitarian Aid, Francis Fedden and Anna Maciag for their generous donations.

OTHER INFORMATION

During the year ahead we have 8 important projects that urgently need funding. A detailed report is available on each project.

The achievements of the Trust (reg. charity no. 1107300, www.mihaieminescutrust.org) are only made possible by your donations. Those made in the UK qualify for Gift Aid. Please send cheques to The Mihai Eminescu Trust, 63 Hillgate Place London W8 7SS. For any information about our activities as well as books and brochures, please contact our office at Tel 0207 229 7618, fax 0207 792 9998.

Email admin@mihaieminescutrust.org;
Guesthouses guesthouses@mihaieminescutrust.org;
Crafted Tours info@realityandbeyond.co.uk